

AI Outage Playbook

On Sept 3, 2026, ChatGPT, Claude, and Grok all had outages the same morning. For most people it was an annoying few hours. For a business with AI wired into intake, quoting, or client replies, work stopped, or kept going with nobody noticing the AI step had failed. This playbook gets you ready for the next one in an afternoon.

START HERE: THE ONE-HOUR TEST

Pick your most customer-facing AI workflow. During a quiet hour, switch the AI step off and watch what your team does. Whatever breaks is your real continuity plan, written for you. Note it on page 2.

WHAT'S INSIDE

- ☐ **Page 1.** AI dependency map: every workflow that calls an AI tool.
- ☐ **Page 2.** Blast-radius scoring: what to protect first.
- ☐ **Page 3.** Manual fallback scripts for intake, quoting, client replies, and scheduling.
- ☐ **Page 4.** Vendor status-alert checklist and your quarterly drill.

STEP 1 · AI DEPENDENCY MAP

Include the hidden ones: the form plugin, inbox rule, or automation someone set up once and forgot.

Workflow	AI tool / vendor	Customer-facing?	What breaks if it's down	Owner	Fallback written?
Website intake form	Chat assistant	Yes	Leads get no reply	Office mgr	No

STEP 2 · RANK BY BLAST RADIUS

Score each workflow, protect the top first

Score 1 (low) to 3 (high) on each question. Anything that totals 9 or more gets a written manual path this month.

Question	1	2	3
Customer impact. Does a client notice?	No	Delayed	Yes, right away
Time sensitivity. What does 4 hours cost?	Nothing	Some rework	Lost work or deadline
Data risk. Could a failure expose client data?	No	Unlikely	Yes
Silent failure. Would anyone notice it broke?	Instantly	Same day	Maybe never

Workflow	Impact	Time	Data	Silent	Total

ONE-HOUR TEST NOTES

Workflow tested, date, what broke, who noticed, how long until someone noticed:

STEP 3 · MANUAL FALLBACK SCRIPTS

If this is down, a human does ___ using ___

Finish that sentence for every workflow that scored 9 or more. Start from these scripts and edit them to fit.

Intake and lead replies

If AI is down, a human does: A staff member checks the intake inbox every hour and replies from a saved template.

What the client hears: "Thanks for reaching out. We got your message and a member of our team will reply personally by [time]."

Who: _____ Where the template lives: _____

Quotes and estimates

If AI is down, a human does: Use the last approved quote template and price sheet. Quotes wait for a human review before sending.

What the client hears: "Thanks for your patience. Your quote is being prepared by our team and will arrive by [day]."

Who: _____ Where the template lives: _____

Client replies and support

If AI is down, a human does: Turn off AI drafting. Replies come from saved responses in the shared inbox; anything unusual goes to the owner.

What the client hears: "We're handling replies personally today, so responses may take a little longer. You'll hear from us by [time]."

Who: _____ Where the template lives: _____

Scheduling

If AI is down, a human does: Pause automated booking. A staff member confirms appointments by phone or email from the calendar.

What the client hears: "Our online booking is paused briefly. Reply with two times that work and we'll confirm today."

Who: _____ Where the template lives: _____

+ Your own For any workflow not covered above

Workflow: _____

If this is down, a human does _____

using _____

What the client hears: _____

STEP 4 · DON'T SINGLE-SOURCE CRITICAL WORK

- ☐ For each workflow scoring 9 or more, pick a second model or vendor you could switch to.
- ☐ Test the backup on one real task before you need it. Note any prompt or format changes it needs.
- ☐ Backup for _____ is _____, tested on _____

STEP 5 · VENDOR STATUS-ALERT CHECKLIST

- ☐ List every AI vendor from your dependency map, including tools with AI built in.
- ☐ Subscribe to each vendor's status page by email or RSS. Most publish one (for example, status.openai.com).
- ☐ Route alerts to a shared inbox or channel, not one person's email.
- ☐ Decide who declares an outage and switches to the manual path.
- ☐ Tell your team where the fallback scripts live.

Vendor	Status page	Subscribed (date)	Alerts go to

QUARTERLY DRILL

- ☐ Drill date: _____ Workflow: _____
- ☐ Run the one-hour test again. Time how long until someone notices.
- ☐ Update the dependency map with any new AI tools added since the last drill.
- ☐ A plan nobody has run isn't a plan.